# Fennel and the Big Gray Worry

A story about feeling worried

by KUZU NOHA

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First edition. Printed by Amazon KDP.

For every little bear
with a big feeling.

Tomorrow was Fennel's first day of school.

He packed his new backpack.
“This will be cool!”

But when the moon rose
and the house grew still,

a tiny thought wiggled and gave him a chill.

“What if I get lost? What if no one plays?

What if I forget what my teacher says?”

Each “what if” became a gray, tangly thread,

and they twisted and tangled inside his head.

The tangle grew bigger. It filled up his bed.

It squeezed in his tummy
and buzzed in his head.

“Mama,” whispered Fennel,
“I have a Big Gray Worry.”

Mama Bear came in, no hurry, no hurry.

“First, SAY it out loud.
Let the worry come out.”

“What if no one plays with me?” sniffed Fennel, in doubt.

“Next, UNTANGLE it. One thread at a time.

What is one small thing
that could make it fine?”

“I could smile,” said Fennel. “I could say hello.

I could ask, ‘Can I play?’ and give it a go.”

“Last, take one small STEP. That’s all you need.”

The gray tangle shrank to a small ball of thread.

Next morning at the
gate, his tummy went flip,

but he took one small step
and he gave a small skip.

A bunny in blue said, “Hi! Want to play?”

And Fennel's Big Gray
Worry just floated away.

# Fennel's 3 Worry Steps

## 1. SAY IT

**Say the worry out loud.**

## 2. UNTANGLE

**Find one small thing you can do.**

## 3. STEP

Take one small step.

**Worries get smaller**

when we share them.

# A Note for Grown-Ups

Name the feeling: “You feel worried.”

Listen first. You do not need to fix it.

Break it into one small step to try.

Celebrate brave steps, big or small.

# Thank you for reading!

If Fennel helped your little one, a short review on Amazon helps other families find this book.